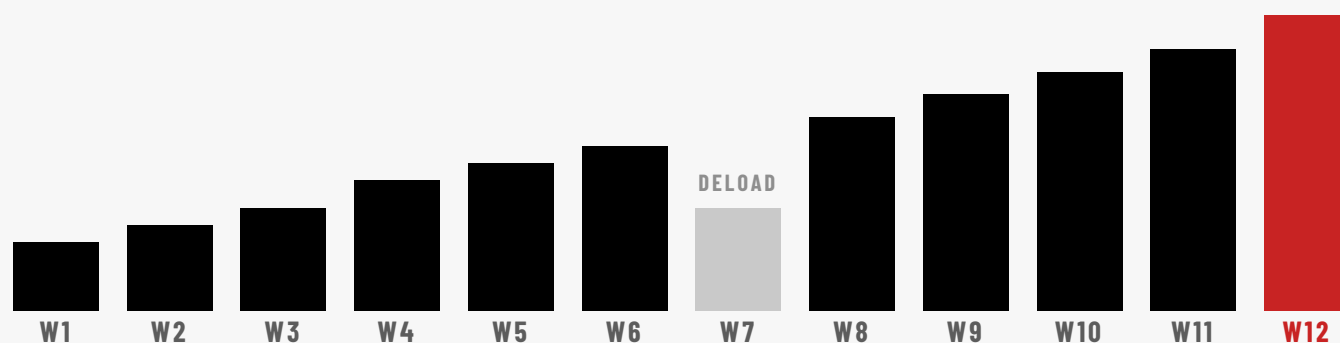


• FREE WORKBOOK – ISSUE 02

# The 12-Week *Progressive Overload* Workbook



Exactly what to add, and when, every week for 12 weeks. Plus the log pages to track every set.



**p.06**  
**THE DOUBLE PROGRESSION RULE**  
The one method a beginner needs

**p.11**  
**COACH INTERVIEW**  
"Small wins, every week"

**p.04**  
**THE NEW RULES OF 2026**  
ACSM's first update in 17 years

**p.15**  
**PRINTABLE TRAINING LOGS**  
Track every set, every week

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The science of progressive overload

**04 THE NEW RULES OF 2026**

ACSM guidelines in plain English

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Weight is only one of them

**06 THE DOUBLE PROGRESSION RULE**

When to add reps, when to add weight

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Quick answers, real research

## FROM THE COACH

# Now what?

Issue 01 gave you a starting point: the right reps, the right sets and a simple three-day plan. This issue answers the question that comes next. *What do I do now?*

The answer is progressive overload: doing a little more over time. Most people know the phrase. Far fewer have a plan for it, so they lift the same weights for months and wonder why nothing changes.

This workbook is that plan. Twelve weeks, three sessions a week, and one clear rule that tells you when to add weight. Every page is built to be used, not only read. Fill in the logs, tick off the weeks, and look back at week 1 when you reach week 12.

Print the log pages. Bring them to the gym. Write everything down.

**Sadia Baloch**

Certified Fitness Coach,  
ExerciseMenu.com

**7+**

YEARS COACHING

**257+**

CLIENTS

**95%**

SATISFACTION

**1. READ**

Pages 3–8  
once, before  
week 1.

**2. TRAIN**

Follow pages  
9–10 three  
times a week.

**3. LOG**

Fill in pages  
15–16 after  
every  
session.

## FEATURE

# Why your workouts *stop working*

*Why progress stalls after a few good months, and the principle that gets it moving again.*

**Y**our first month of training feels like magic. The weights climb, your clothes fit differently and every session brings something new. Then, somewhere around week six or eight, it stalls. Same weights. Same reps. Same reflection in the mirror.

Nothing is wrong with you. Your body did what it was built to do: it adapted to the demand you gave it. Muscles grow and get stronger because training creates a stress they are not yet prepared for. Once they handle that stress comfortably, they have no reason to change further.

That is the whole idea behind **progressive overload**: gradually increasing the demand on your muscles so there is always a new reason to adapt. The American College of Sports Medicine (ACSM) describes progression as necessary if you want your body to keep adapting.<sup>1</sup>

---

**“Your body adapts to what you ask of it. Progressive overload means you *never stop asking*.”**

---

## More weight is not the only way

Most people hear “progressive overload” and think it means adding plates. Weight is one tool, not the only one. In a 2022 study published in *PeerJ*, trained lifters followed one of two plans for eight weeks. One group added weight and kept their reps the same. The other kept the weight the same and added reps. Both groups gained similar muscle size and strength.<sup>2</sup>

That finding shapes this workbook. You will progress by adding reps first, then weight, a method called **double progression** (page 6). It works with dumbbells at home, machines at a busy gym or a barbell, and it tells you exactly when to move up.

## Effort is the part you cannot skip

Adding reps or weight only works if your sets are hard enough to matter. The 2026 ACSM guidelines note that light and heavy loads both build muscle, as long as each set is taken close to failure. You don’t need to reach failure; stopping a couple of reps short works.<sup>3</sup> Stop too early and your log looks good on paper while your muscles barely notice.

So every session in this plan asks two things of you: do a little more than last time, and make each set count. The next pages show you how.

---

<sup>1</sup> ACSM Position Stand, [Progression Models in Resistance Training](#) (2009) · <sup>2</sup> Plotkin et al., [PeerJ](#) (2022) · <sup>3</sup> ACSM Position Stand, [Resistance Training Prescription](#) (2026) · Go deeper: [What is progressive overload?](#)

## WHAT CHANGED IN 2026

# The new rules of *strength training*

*In 2026 the ACSM updated its resistance training guidelines for the first time in 17 years, drawing on 137 systematic reviews and more than 30,000 people. Here is what it means for you.*

## 01

### ANY TRAINING BEATS NONE

The biggest jump in results comes from going from no training to regular training. A plan you follow beats a perfect plan you skip.

## 02

### TRAIN EACH MUSCLE TWICE A WEEK

At least two sessions per muscle group each week. This plan's three full-body days train most major muscles three times.

## 03

### 10+ WEEKLY SETS FOR GROWTH

For muscle size, aim for at least 10 sets per muscle group per week. This plan works up to about 9–10 for most muscles.

## 04

### YOU DON'T NEED TO HIT FAILURE

Training to absolute failure isn't required. Stopping a few reps short gives similar results with less fatigue.

## 05

### LIGHT OR HEAVY BOTH BUILD MUSCLE

Loads from 30% to 100% of your max all work for growth, as long as each set is taken close to failure.

## 06

### HEAVIER FOR PURE STRENGTH

For maximum strength, the guidelines favour heavier loads (80%+ of your one-rep max) on key lifts done early in the session.

#### IN THIS WORKBOOK

## How this plan follows the 2026 guidelines

- ✓ Three sessions a week, so most muscles are trained 3×
- ✓ About 9–10 weekly sets for most major muscles from week 4
- ✓ Target of 1–3 reps in reserve, never grinding to failure
- ✓ Big compound lifts first, while you are fresh

Source: ACSM Position Stand, [Resistance Training Prescription for Muscle Function, Hypertrophy, and Physical Performance in Healthy Adults](#) (2026) and the [ACSM announcement](#). Summarised for general readers.

## THE TOOLKIT

# 7 ways to progress, *not just weight*

Weight is one lever. Here are seven, with the right moment to pull each one.

- |   |                                                                                                                      |                                         |
|---|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>ADD WEIGHT</b><br>The classic. Use it once you hit the top of your rep range on every set.                        | <b>BENCH</b><br><b>30 → 32.5 KG</b>     |
| 2 | <b>ADD REPS</b><br>Same weight, one more rep. Your default move in this plan.                                        | <b>SQUAT</b><br><b>3×8 → 3×9</b>        |
| 3 | <b>ADD A SET</b><br>More total work. This plan adds sets at the start of weeks 4 and 8.                              | <b>ROW</b><br><b>2 → 3 SETS</b>         |
| 4 | <b>SLOW THE LOWERING</b><br>A 3-second lowering phase adds time under tension. Useful when you lack heavier weights. | <b>TEMPO</b><br><b>1 S → 3 S DOWN</b>   |
| 5 | <b>INCREASE RANGE OF MOTION</b><br>Deeper squats, a fuller stretch at the bottom. Build range before you add load.   | <b>SQUAT</b><br><b>BOX → FULL DEPTH</b> |
| 6 | <b>HARDER VARIATION</b><br>Use it when the smallest weight jump available is too big for you.                        | <b>PUSH-UP</b><br><b>KNEES → TOES</b>   |
| 7 | <b>CUT REST TIME</b><br>Same work in less time. Better for fitness than for size, so use it sparingly.               | <b>REST</b><br><b>120 S → 90 S</b>      |

## WHICH LEVER, WHEN?

### GYM WITH FULL EQUIPMENT

Use 1 and 2 (reps, then weight). Add 3 at the planned weeks.

### HOME, LIMITED WEIGHTS

Use 2, 4, 5 and 6 once your heaviest dumbbells stop being hard.

### SHORT ON TIME

Keep sets and reps; use 7 carefully, and never below 60 seconds on big lifts.

**Change one thing at a time.** If you add weight and cut rest in the same week and the session goes badly, you won't know which change caused it.

Go deeper: [Progressive overload without adding weight](#) · [Time under tension](#)

## THE ONE RULE

# The double *progression* rule

One rule decides every progression in this plan. Learn it once and use it for years.

## THE RULE

Work inside a rep range. When you hit the *top of the range on every set* with good form, add the smallest weight jump you can. Then build the reps back up.



## EXAMPLE: DUMBBELL BENCH PRESS, 8-12 REPS

| SESSION | WEIGHT | REPS (3 SETS) | NEXT         |
|---------|--------|---------------|--------------|
| 1       | 14 kg  | 9 · 8 · 8     | Add reps     |
| 2       | 14 kg  | 10 · 9 · 8    | Add reps     |
| 3       | 14 kg  | 11 · 10 · 10  | Add reps     |
| 4       | 14 kg  | 12 · 11 · 11  | Add reps     |
| 5       | 14 kg  | 12 · 12 · 12  | Add weight ✓ |
| 6       | 16 kg  | 9 · 8 · 8     | Build again  |

## HOW MUCH TO ADD

| LIFT TYPE                             | ADD                            |
|---------------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| <b>Upper body</b><br>presses, rows    | 1–2.5 kg<br>or next dumbbell   |
| <b>Lower body</b><br>squat, RDL       | 2.5–5 kg                       |
| <b>Small muscles</b><br>curls, raises | Go 2–3 reps past the top first |

**Research check:** the ACSM progression model suggests a 2–10% load increase once you can do 1–2 reps more than your target on two sessions in a row.<sup>1</sup> To play it safe, wait until you hit the top of the range two sessions in a row before adding weight.

## 3 MISTAKES THAT BREAK THE RULE

## ✗ COUNTING UGLY REPS

Half-depth squats and bounced presses don't count toward the top of the range.

## ✗ JUMPING TOO FAR

Add the smallest weight available. Big jumps make reps crash and form slip.

## ✗ ADDING WEIGHT EVERYWHERE

Each exercise moves on its own schedule. Squats may jump twice before curls jump once.

<sup>1</sup> ACSM Position Stand, *Progression Models in Resistance Training* (2009)

## BEFORE YOU START

# Find your *starting weight*

No guesswork and no max testing. Use reps in reserve to pick the right weight in your first week.

**Reps in reserve (RIR)** is how many more clean reps you could have done when you stopped the set. It is the simplest way to measure effort. Research supports it for new and experienced lifters, and your accuracy improves with practice.<sup>4</sup> Every set in this plan has an RIR target.

0

**FAILURE**

Couldn't do another rep. Avoid in this plan.

1

**NEAR MAX**

One rep left. Last sets, weeks 9–12.

2

**HARD**

Two reps left. Your main target.

3

**SOLID**

Three reps left. Weeks 1–3 while learning.

4+

**TOO EASY**

Add weight on the next set.

## THE 3-STEP TEST

- 1 Choose a weight you think you could lift about 12 times.
- 2 Do 8 reps, then stop and ask: how many more could I do with clean form?
- 3 Adjust with the table, then write the weight in your log.

| REPS LEFT AFTER 8 | WHAT TO DO                              |
|-------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 5 or more         | Too light. Add 10–20% next set.         |
| 3–4               | Your starting weight for weeks 1–3.     |
| 1–2               | Good for later. For week 1, drop 5–10%. |
| 0 / form broke    | Too heavy. Drop 15–20%.                 |

**ALREADY KNOW A REP MAX?**

Estimate your one-rep max with the Brzycki formula:

$$1RM = \text{weight} \div (1.0278 - 0.0278 \times \text{reps})$$

Start this plan at about 60–65% of that number.

**CALIBRATE ONCE A WEEK**

New lifters often stop sets further from failure than they think. Once a week, take the last set of one exercise to 1 RIR to check what “hard” feels like.

**YOUR FIRST SESSION CHECKLIST**

- ☐ Log pages printed (p.15)
- ☐ 5-minute warm-up done
- ☐ Pen or phone for notes
- ☐ Starting weight found for each lift

<sup>4</sup> Zourdos et al., *J Strength Cond Res* (2016) · Go deeper: [RPE vs RIR explained](#) · [How to calculate your 1RM](#)

## THE BIG PICTURE

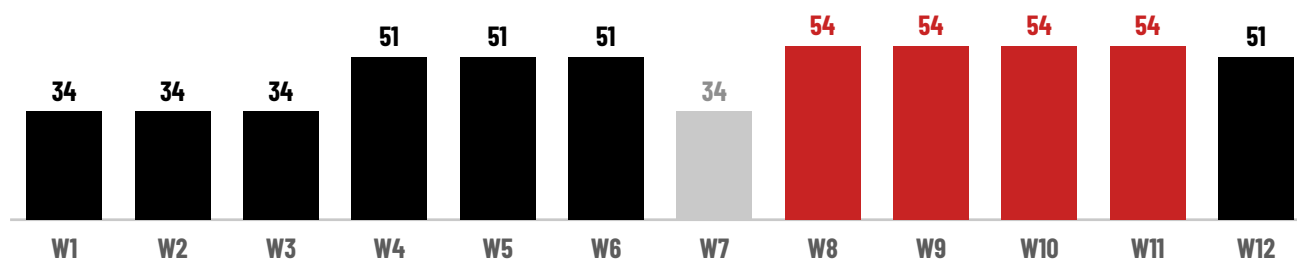
# Your 12-week map

Four phases, one direction. Each phase asks a little more, and one lighter week keeps you fresh.

|                             |                                                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>WEEKS</b><br><b>1–3</b>  | <b>LEARN 2 SETS • 3 RIR</b><br>Learn the lifts, find your weights and log every set. Add a rep wherever form allows.                     |
| <b>WEEKS</b><br><b>4–6</b>  | <b>BUILD 3 SETS • 2 RIR</b><br>Add the third set. Run double progression on every exercise; expect your first weight jumps.              |
| <b>WEEK</b><br><b>7</b>     | <b>DELOAD 2 SETS • 4 RIR</b><br>Same weights, fewer sets, easier effort. Fatigue clears so you start week 8 fresh.                       |
| <b>WEEKS</b><br><b>8–11</b> | <b>PUSH 3–4 SETS • 1–2 RIR</b><br>Four sets on the first exercise of each day. From week 9, take the last set of each exercise to 1 RIR. |
| <b>WEEK</b><br><b>12</b>    | <b>TEST 3 SETS • 1–2 RIR</b><br>Record your best set on every main lift and compare it with week 1.                                      |

## TOTAL WORKING SETS PER WEEK

Volume builds, dips at week 7, then builds again



## YOUR WEEK

|                        |                           |                        |                           |                        |                             |                           |
|------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>MON</b><br><b>A</b> | <b>TUE</b><br><b>WALK</b> | <b>WED</b><br><b>B</b> | <b>THU</b><br><b>REST</b> | <b>FRI</b><br><b>C</b> | <b>SAT</b><br><b>ACTIVE</b> | <b>SUN</b><br><b>REST</b> |
|------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------|---------------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------|

**Why sets go up in weeks 4 and 8:** more weekly sets means more growth, up to a point.<sup>5</sup> Adding them in steps lets your recovery keep up.

**Can't train Mon–Wed–Fri?** Any three days work. Just leave at least one rest day between sessions.

<sup>5</sup> Schoenfeld et al., *J Sports Sci* (2017) • Go deeper: [What is a deload week?](#)

## THREE FULL-BODY DAYS

## The workouts

**Sets per exercise:** 2 (weeks 1–3) · 3 (weeks 4–6) · 2 (week 7) · 3, with 4 on exercise 1 (weeks 8–11) · 3 (week 12)

**Warm up every session:** 5 minutes of light cardio, then 2 lighter sets of your first exercise. About 45–60 minutes per session in total.

## A SQUAT &amp; PUSH Monday

| EXERCISE               | REPS    | REST  | HOME SWAP                    |
|------------------------|---------|-------|------------------------------|
| 1 Goblet or back squat | 8–12    | 2 min | Goblet squat, heavy dumbbell |
| 2 Dumbbell bench press | 8–12    | 90 s  | Floor press or push-up       |
| 3 One-arm dumbbell row | 10–15   | 90 s  | Same                         |
| 4 Lateral raise        | 12–20   | 60 s  | Same, or band raise          |
| 5 Plank                | 30–60 s | 60 s  | Same (add 10 s to progress)  |

## B HINGE &amp; PULL Wednesday

| EXERCISE                  | REPS          | REST  | HOME SWAP                          |
|---------------------------|---------------|-------|------------------------------------|
| 1 Romanian deadlift       | 8–12          | 2 min | Dumbbell RDL                       |
| 2 Overhead press          | 8–12          | 90 s  | Seated dumbbell press              |
| 3 Lat pulldown            | 10–15         | 90 s  | Band pulldown or chin-up negatives |
| 4 Split squat<br>each leg | 10–15         | 90 s  | Same, holding dumbbells            |
| 5 Push-up                 | Stop at 2 RIR | 60 s  | Same (knees if needed)             |
| 6 Dead bug<br>each side   | 8–12          | 60 s  | Same                               |

## C LEGS &amp; UPPER Friday

| EXERCISE                 | REPS  | REST  | HOME SWAP                    |
|--------------------------|-------|-------|------------------------------|
| 1 Leg press              | 10–15 | 2 min | Dumbbell step-up             |
| 2 Incline dumbbell press | 8–12  | 90 s  | Feet-elevated push-up        |
| 3 Seated cable row       | 10–15 | 90 s  | Chest-supported dumbbell row |
| 4 Hip thrust             | 8–12  | 90 s  | Dumbbell glute bridge        |
| 5 Dumbbell curl          | 10–15 | 60 s  | Same                         |
| 6 Triceps pushdown       | 10–15 | 60 s  | Overhead dumbbell extension  |

Go deeper: [Warm-up sets vs working sets](#) · [How many sets per muscle group per week?](#)

TICK IT OFF

# Week-by-week *targets*

One focus per week. Tick a box after each session and watch 36 boxes fill up.

| WK | PHASE         | SETS | RIR | THIS WEEK'S FOCUS                                      | A B C                                                                      |
|----|---------------|------|-----|--------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | Learn         | 2    | 3   | Find starting weights (p.07). Log every set.           | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 2  | Learn         | 2    | 3   | Add 1 rep per set wherever form allows.                | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 3  | Learn         | 2    | 3   | Film one set of squats and RDLs to check form.         | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 4  | Build         | 3    | 2   | Add the third set. Weights can stay the same.          | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 5  | Build         | 3    | 2   | First weight jumps on lifts at the top of their range. | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 6  | Build         | 3    | 2   | Fill in the week 6 checkpoint below.                   | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 7  | <b>Deload</b> | 2    | 4   | Same weights, fewer sets. Aim for 8 hours of sleep.    | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 8  | Push          | 3-4  | 2   | 4 sets on the first exercise of each day.              | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 9  | Push          | 3-4  | 1-2 | Last set of each exercise at 1 RIR.                    | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 10 | Push          | 3-4  | 1-2 | Lift stuck? Use the Plateau Fixer (p.14).              | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 11 | Push          | 3-4  | 1-2 | Last hard week. Note your best sets.                   | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |
| 12 | <b>Test</b>   | 3    | 1-2 | Record best sets. Compare with week 1 (p.16).          | <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> <input type="checkbox"/> |

**Missed a session?** Don't double up. Do the next workout in the order A → B → C and carry on. One missed day changes nothing; a missed month does.

**Bad day?** If every lift feels heavy, match last week's numbers instead of beating them. Holding steady on a bad day still counts.

CHECKPOINT: END OF WEEK 6

SESSIONS DONE \_\_\_ / 18

LIFTS THAT MOVED UP IN WEIGHT

CHECKPOINT: END OF WEEK 12

SESSIONS DONE \_\_\_ / 36

BIGGEST JUMP SINCE WEEK 1

## CONVERSATION

# SADIA BALOCH: SMALL WINS, EVERY WEEK

EM

By ExerciseMenu Editorial  
Interview with our head coach

**S**tarting is the easy part. Knowing what to do in week five, week eight and week twelve is harder. We asked our head coach how she takes a new client from their first week to their twelfth, and what she changes when progress slows.

**Q: WHEN A NEW CLIENT STARTS, WHAT DO YOU LOOK AT FIRST?**

**A:** Their habits, not their strength. I want to know how many days a week they can train without the rest of their life falling apart. After that, I watch them move: a squat, a push-up, a row. That tells me where to start far better than any test.

**Q: WHAT DOES THE FIRST MONTH LOOK LIKE?**

**A:** Boring, on purpose. We keep the weights manageable, the reps controlled, and I ask them to write everything down. The goal for month one is to own the movements. People are surprised how quickly they get stronger just by learning

the lifts properly. A lot of that early progress is the nervous system getting better at the skill.

**Q: HOW DO YOU DECIDE WHEN A CLIENT SHOULD ADD WEIGHT?**

**A:** When they hit the top of their rep range on every set and the last rep looks like the first. That's the double progression rule in this workbook. I never add weight because a client feels good on one day. It has to show up in the log, not only in how they feel.

**Q: WHAT'S THE BIGGEST MISTAKE YOU SEE IN THE FIRST 12 WEEKS?**

**A:** Adding weight too fast. Someone has a great week, jumps five kilos, their form falls apart and they stall or get hurt. Small jumps, often, win every time.

---

**“Three sessions they show up for *beat five sessions they skip.*”**

---

**Q: WHAT DO YOU CHANGE FIRST WHEN A CLIENT STOPS PROGRESSING?**

**A:** I check sleep and food before I touch the program. Most stalls I see are recovery problems in disguise. If recovery is fine, I look at effort: are they stopping sets too early? Only then do I change the exercises or the rep range.

**Q: WHY IS THERE A LIGHTER WEEK IN THE MIDDLE OF THE PLAN?**

**A:** Fatigue builds quietly. By week six most people are carrying more of it than they realise. One easier week lets it clear, and clients often come back in week eight stronger than they left week six.

**Q: WHAT DOES A SUCCESSFUL 12 WEEKS LOOK LIKE?**

**A:** Thirty-six sessions logged, or close to it. Better form. Weights that were hard in week one feel manageable. The numbers matter, but consistency is the real result, because it carries into the next twelve weeks.

**Q: ONE PIECE OF ADVICE FOR SOMEONE STARTING TODAY?**

**A:** Write it down. Every set, every session. Your log is your coach when I'm not there. When you feel stuck, open it and look at week one.

**THE COACH'S 3 RULES**

- 1 Add reps before you add weight.
- 2 Fix recovery before you change the program.
- 3 If it isn't written down, it didn't happen.

“

**I'd rather a client add one rep a week for twelve weeks than add a big weight once and spend a month stuck.**

**SB****HEAD COACH**

ExerciseMenu.com

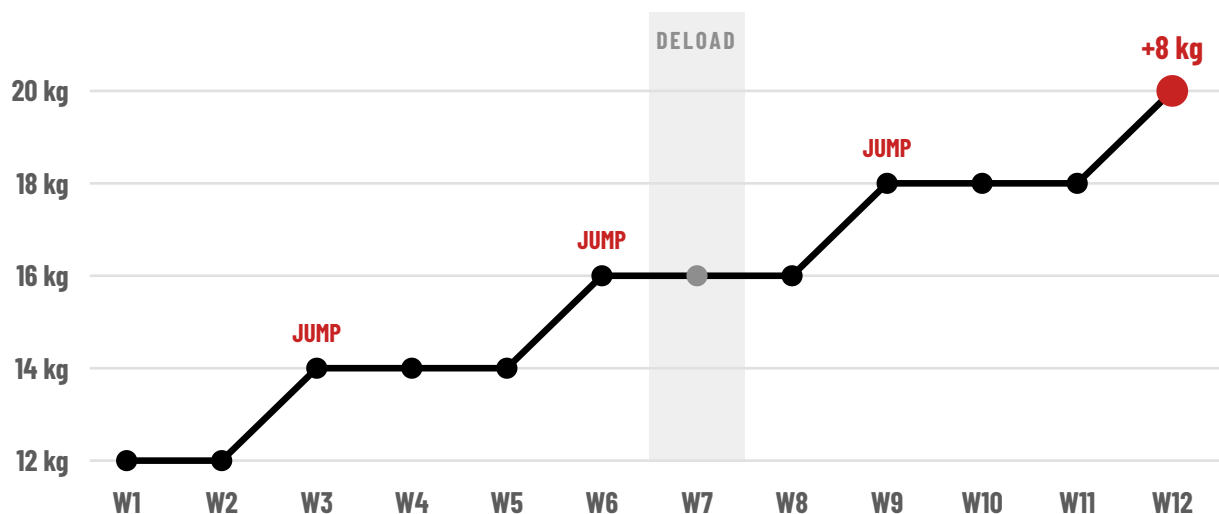
## ILLUSTRATIVE EXAMPLE

# 12 weeks *on paper*

How one lift can move through this plan. Your numbers will differ, but the pattern is what matters.

## DUMBBELL BENCH PRESS: WEIGHT PER HAND

Example trainee, 8–12 rep range



### 01

#### FLAT WEEKS ARE PROGRESS

The weight often stays the same for 2–3 weeks while reps climb. The flat parts of the line are where the next jump is built.

### 02

#### A DELOAD IS NOT A STEP BACK

In week 7 the sets drop but the weight holds. On the chart the line stays flat. It doesn't go down.

### 03

#### SMALL LIFTS MOVE SLOWER

Squats and presses jump every 1–3 weeks early on. Raises and curls may take far longer. That is normal.

**Your turn:** write your week 1 and week 12 best sets on the Progress Tracker (p.16). Comparing the two is the most motivating page in this workbook.

This is an illustrative example built from the plan's rules, not data from a real client.

## WHEN THINGS STALL

# Stuck? The *plateau fixer*

*Find what you're seeing in the left column. Check the cause, then try the fix for two weeks.*

| IF THIS HAPPENS                                  | CHECK THIS                         | TRY THIS                                                            |
|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Same reps for 2+ weeks</b> on one lift        | Effort: are sets ending at 3+ RIR? | Take the last set to 1 RIR for two sessions.                        |
| <b>Reps dropping</b> on most lifts               | Sleep and recovery                 | Aim for 7–9 hours; take the deload a week early.                    |
| <b>Can't reach the range</b> after a weight jump | The jump was too big               | Go back down; use rep or tempo progress to bridge.                  |
| <b>Form breaks</b> on the last reps              | Load too heavy                     | Drop 5–10% and lower the weight over 3 seconds.                     |
| <b>Joint pain</b> (not muscle soreness)          | Exercise choice                    | Swap to a pain-free variation. See a professional if it persists.   |
| <b>Skipping sessions</b>                         | Schedule and motivation            | Keep the plan; swap one accessory lift for a similar one you enjoy. |

## RECOVERY ESSENTIALS

## 7–9h

### SLEEP

Sleep is when much of your recovery happens. Short sleep over several nights shows up as weaker sessions. [Sleep & muscle growth](#)

## 1.6 g

### PROTEIN PER KG

A meta-analysis of 49 studies found gains levelled off around 1.6 g of protein per kg of body weight per day.<sup>6</sup> At 70 kg, that's about 112 g a day.

## 48h

### REST BETWEEN

Leave a day between sessions. Walks and light movement on off days count as active recovery. [Rest vs active recovery](#)

<sup>6</sup> Morton et al., *Br J Sports Med* (2018)

# Weekly *training log*

Write reps in each set box.  
Circle the lift you'll add weight to next time.

| WEEK                                | DATES | PHASE             |       |       |                           | TARGET RIR |           |
|-------------------------------------|-------|-------------------|-------|-------|---------------------------|------------|-----------|
| EXERCISE                            | KG    | SET 1             | SET 2 | SET 3 | SET 4                     | RIR        | NEXT TIME |
| <b>WORKOUT A • SQUAT &amp; PUSH</b> |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Squat                               |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| DB bench press                      |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| One-arm row                         |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Lateral raise                       |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Plank (sec)                         |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| <b>WORKOUT B • HINGE &amp; PULL</b> |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Romanian deadlift                   |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Overhead press                      |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Lat pulldown                        |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Split squat                         |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Push-up                             |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Dead bug                            |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| <b>WORKOUT C • LEGS &amp; UPPER</b> |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Leg press                           |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Incline DB press                    |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Seated cable row                    |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Hip thrust                          |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| DB curl                             |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| Triceps pushdown                    |       |                   |       |       |                           |            |           |
| <b>AVG SLEEP (H)</b>                |       | <b>ENERGY 1-5</b> |       |       | <b>BEST SET THIS WEEK</b> |            |           |

# 12-week *progress tracker*

Each week, write your best set for each main lift as **kg × reps** (e.g. 16×10).

| LIFT           | 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 | 7 | 8 | 9 | 10 | 11 | 12 |
|----------------|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|----|----|----|
| Squat          |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |    |    |    |
| DB bench       |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |    |    |    |
| Row            |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |    |    |    |
| RDL            |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |    |    |    |
| Overhead press |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |    |    |    |
| Pulldown       |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |    |    |    |
| Hip thrust     |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |   |    |    |    |

## SESSIONS COMPLETED: TICK ONE PER WORKOUT

|    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |    |
|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|----|
| 1  | 2  | 3  | 4  | 5  | 6  | 7  | 8  | 9  | 10 | 11 | 12 | 13 | 14 | 15 | 16 | 17 | 18 | 19 | 20 |
| 21 | 22 | 23 | 24 | 25 | 26 | 27 | 28 | 29 | 30 | 31 | 32 | 33 | 34 | 35 | 36 |    |    |    |    |

## BODY CHECK (optional)

| MEASURE              | WEEK 1 | WEEK 6 | WEEK 12 |
|----------------------|--------|--------|---------|
| Body weight          |        |        |         |
| Waist (cm)           |        |        |         |
| Progress photo taken |        |        |         |

### WEEK 1 VS WEEK 12

BIGGEST IMPROVEMENT

LIFT THAT FELT EASIEST BY THE END

HOW MY CLOTHES FIT / HOW I FEEL

### NEXT 12 WEEKS

MY GOAL

TWO EXERCISES TO SWAP

START DATE

## YOU ASKED

# Quick *answers*

## Can I do this plan at home with only dumbbells?

Yes. Every exercise has a home swap on page 9. When your heaviest dumbbells get easy, use slower lowering, pauses or one-arm and one-leg versions.

## Should I feel sore after every session?

No. Soreness is common in the first weeks and after new exercises, but it doesn't measure progress. Your log does.

## What do I do after week 12?

Run the plan again starting from your week 12 weights, and swap two or three exercises for close variations to keep it fresh.

## The next dumbbell is too heavy. What now?

Stay at your current weight and go 2–3 reps past the top of the range, or slow the lowering to 3 seconds. Move up once you reach 15 clean reps.

## Can I add cardio?

Yes. Do hard cardio after lifting or on non-lifting days, and keep easy walks on rest days. [Cardio before or after weights?](#)

## I'm over 50. Is this plan for me?

The structure suits most healthy adults. Start at 3–4 RIR and progress reps before weight. [Reps and sets over 50](#)

## SOURCES

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- 6 Morton RW, et al. Protein supplementation and resistance training-induced gains in muscle mass and strength. *Br J Sports Med.* 2018;52(6):376–384. [pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/28698222](https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/28698222)

**Please note:** this workbook is general information, not medical advice. If you have an injury or a medical condition, or you are returning to exercise after a long break, check with your doctor before starting.

KEEP GOING

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01

## HOW MANY SETS PER MUSCLE GROUP PER WEEK?

[exercisemenu.com](https://exercisemenu.com)



02

## HYPERTROPHY VS STRENGTH: WHICH TO PICK

[exercisemenu.com](https://exercisemenu.com)



03

## DROP SETS VS SUPERSETS VS PYRAMID SETS

[exercisemenu.com](https://exercisemenu.com)



04

## RPE VS RIR: HOW HARD SHOULD A SET FEEL?

[exercisemenu.com](https://exercisemenu.com)



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